

Class 8: Politically Violent Activity

Election-related violence

Dr. Michael C. Zeller

Agenda for the day

- Opening notes
- Election-related violence
- Poll: election-related violence
- Back to Violence / Nonviolence
- Any questions, concerns, feedback for this class?

Opening notes



Presentations line-up

Date	Presenters	Method
4 Dec:	Shahadaan, Kristine, Daichi	ethnography
11 Dec:	Bérénice, Zorka, Victoria, Katharina	content analysis
18 Dec:	Shoam, Aidan, Tara, Sebastian	QCA

Election-related violence

- Starter questions
- Harbers, Richetta, and van Wingerden (2022)
 - research design
 - analyses:
 - DV: turnout
 - DV: incumbent vote
 - conclusions



What actors might strategically use violence before or during an election?

Why?

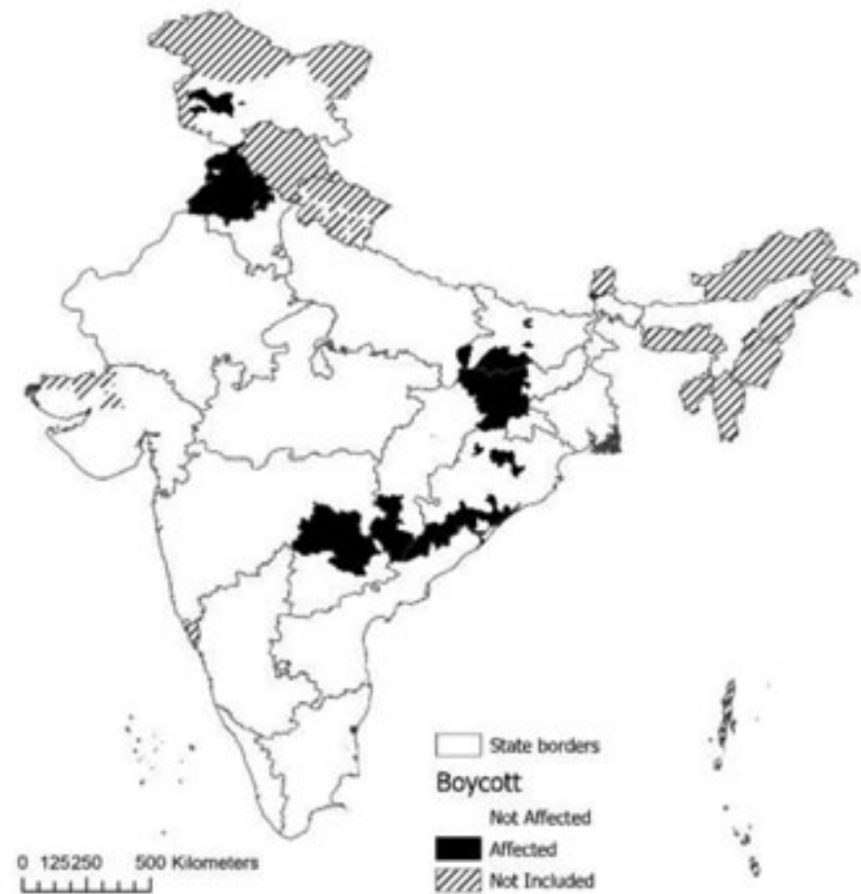
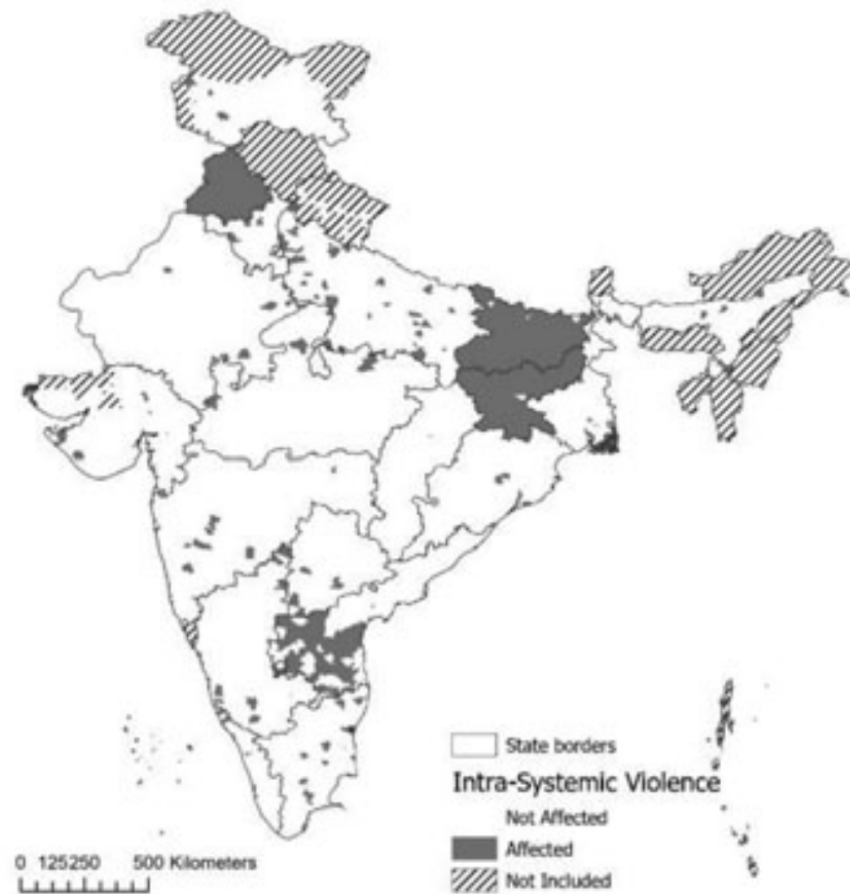
Can you think of any cases of election-related violence?

electoral violence (p. 3): “coercion directed towards actors and/or objects during the electoral cycle ... part of a menu of electoral manipulation, which includes threats and coercion targeting voters, candidates and officials involved in the process”

- **intra-systemic violence**
 - “try to win under the existing system”
 - “suppress or drown out the voices of political opponents”
- **anti-systemic violence**
 - “burn down the house and alter the status quo”
 - “depress participation as much as possible in order to undermine the legitimacy of the election”
- examples from cases? any difference in the *form* of violence?
applicable beyond modern democracies? (e.g., KKK, Wilson, and *The Birth of a Nation*)

- **intra-systemic violence**
- **anti-systemic violence**
- examples from cases? any difference in the *form* of violence?
 - intra-systemic: riots or group clashes between party supporters and violent attacks on candidates, politicians or voters. ... 'booth capture', where armed goons take over polling places
 - anti-systemic: coercion of or threats against candidates, voters, poll workers or security, as well as destruction of election infrastructure

intra-systemic violence (left) and anti-systemic violence (right) in India, 1985-2008



Harbers, Richetta, and van Wingerden (2022) - design

- research aim: looking at *sub-national election-related violence in India*: what effect on electoral outcomes (DVs: turnout, incumbent vote percentage) does violence before elections (IV) have?
- Method: series of fixed-effects and Poisson regression models
 - ↪ fixed-effects - intercept of model varies across units/cases to control for unvarying attributes of specific units/cases
 - ↪ Poisson - often used to model 'count' data
- Data (collection procedure detailed on p. 8):
 - Times of India (ToI) new reports, *sub-national* elections
 - Unit of analysis/case: constituency-year
 - coded: violence intra-systemic or part of armed group's tactic

Reg table, DV: turnout

what findings can you pick out?

Table 1. Results of the fixed-effects analysis, dependent variable: turnout (%)

	Model 1	Model 2	Model 3
Intra-systemic violence			
Non-lethal	−2.834** (0.854)		−2.989*** (0.844)
Lethal	2.242 (1.243)		1.827 (1.225)
Anti-systemic violence			
Boycott call		−18.54*** (4.334)	−18.71*** (4.412)
Non-lethal		−22.96** (7.958)	−23.05** (7.939)
Lethal		−24.78*** (5.016)	−24.92*** (5.088)
Alignment	1.317*** (0.349)	1.158*** (0.313)	1.143*** (0.313)
Margin of victory	−0.0735*** (0.0123)	−0.0618*** (0.0105)	−0.0612*** (0.0105)
Literacy	0.200*** (0.0595)	0.165** (0.0527)	0.162** (0.0530)
Electrification	0.0414 (0.0342)	0.0571 (0.0313)	0.0597 (0.0313)
Urbanization	−0.0350 (0.0800)	−0.0495 (0.0744)	−0.0487 (0.0743)
Turnout ($t - 1$)	0.0586 (0.0381)	0.0966** (0.0342)	0.0974** (0.0342)
Intra-systemic violence (spatial lag)	4.442*** (1.045)		1.983 (1.030)
Intercept	48.68*** (2.368)	47.89*** (2.431)	47.89*** (2.415)
Log likelihood	−64744.4	−63936.7	−63918.4
N	18,982	18,982	18,982
n	3,486	3,486	3,486

Notes: Robust standard errors in parentheses (cluster: district); * $p < 0.05$; ** $p < 0.01$; *** $p < 0.001$: fixed effects at the constituency level.

Reg table, DV: turnout

Reg table, DV: incumbent vote

what findings can you pick out?

Table 3. Results of the fixed-effects analysis, dependent variable: incumbent vote share (%)

	Model 1	Model 2
Intra-systemic violence	−5.257*** (1.150)	−6.140*** (1.243)
Alignment	11.18*** (0.501)	11.00*** (0.490)
Intra-systemic violence x alignment		7.993** (2.521)
Margin of victory	−0.00174 (0.0229)	−0.00159 (0.0230)
Literacy	0.167*** (0.0499)	0.163** (0.0498)
Electrification	0.0235 (0.0444)	0.0255 (0.0443)
Urbanization	0.278** (0.0985)	0.277** (0.0983)
Turnout	0.127*** (0.0259)	0.128*** (0.0258)
Incumbent vote share ($t - 1$)	0.167*** (0.0232)	0.167*** (0.0233)
Intercept	−1.195 (3.159)	−1.104 (3.165)
Log likelihood	−66881.1	−66872.0
N	16,851	16,851
n	3,485	3,485

Note: Robust standard errors in parentheses (cluster: district); * $p < 0.05$; ** $p < 0.01$; *** $p < 0.001$; fixed effects at the constituency level.

Reg table, DV: incumbent vote

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- violence is associated with fewer votes for the constituency-level incumbent party
- positive interaction term ($\beta = 7.993^{***}$) indicates ... the negative effect of violence is diminished if the incumbent is aligned with the state government
 - suggests that within non-aligned constituencies, intra-systemic violence is targeted at supporters of the state-level opposition

- violence decreases turnout but that the **effect is larger for anti-systemic violence**
- intra-systemic violence appears intended to **selectively depress turnout** among opposition supporters
- **anti-systemic violence** “extremely effective in terms of keeping voters away from the polls and thus discrediting the electoral results due to low participation rates”
 - ethics question: qualms about reporting this finding?
- open data on subnational violence: Zhukov, Davenport, and Kostyuk (2019)

how should states respond to electoral violence?

Poll: election-related violence



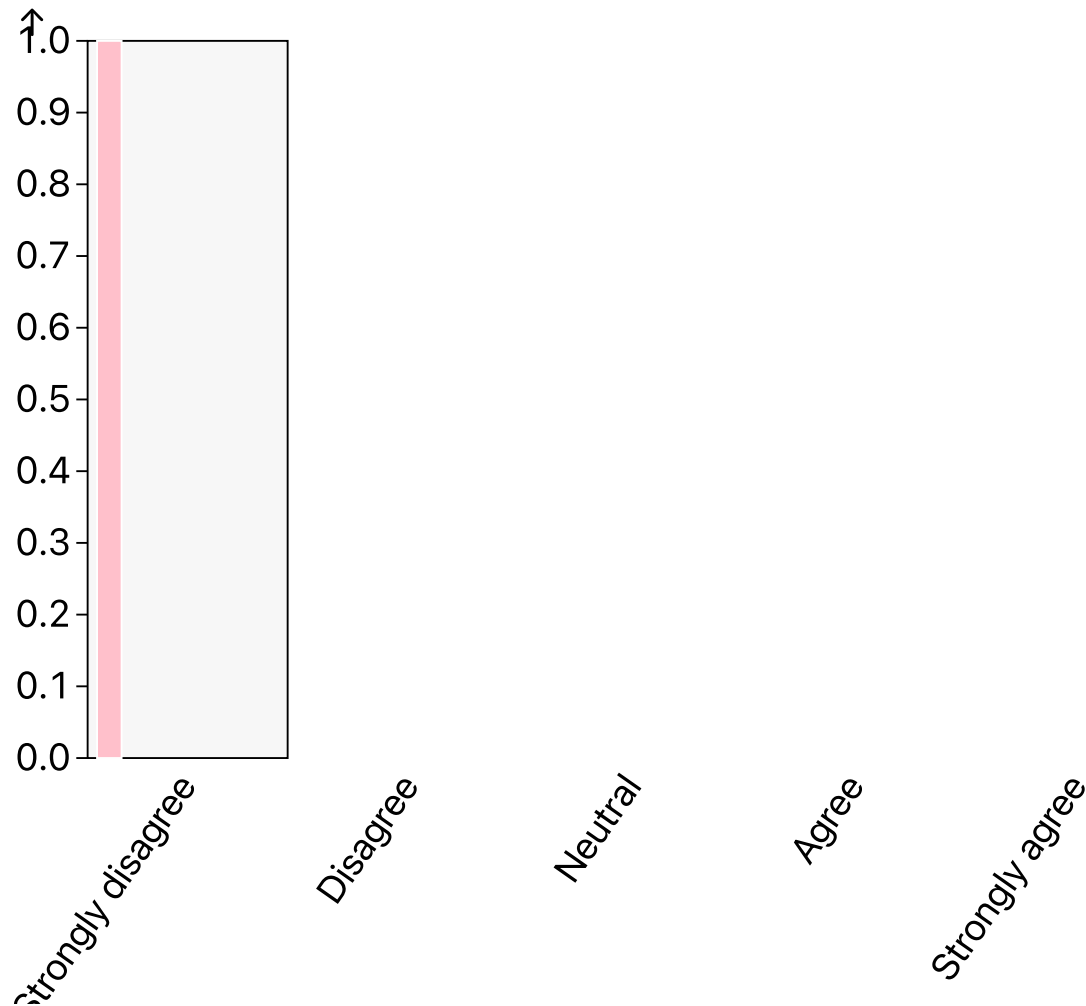
Take the survey at
<https://forms.gle/aFgvV521ZFGC8Rih9>

Questions about groups: (1) Does the group's violence increase around elections? (2) How is the group's violence connected to elections? (3) Has the group intimidated/targeted voters? (4) Has the group intimidated/targeted candidates/office-holders?

Poll results (Respondents: 1) - election violence

Does the group's violence increase around elections?

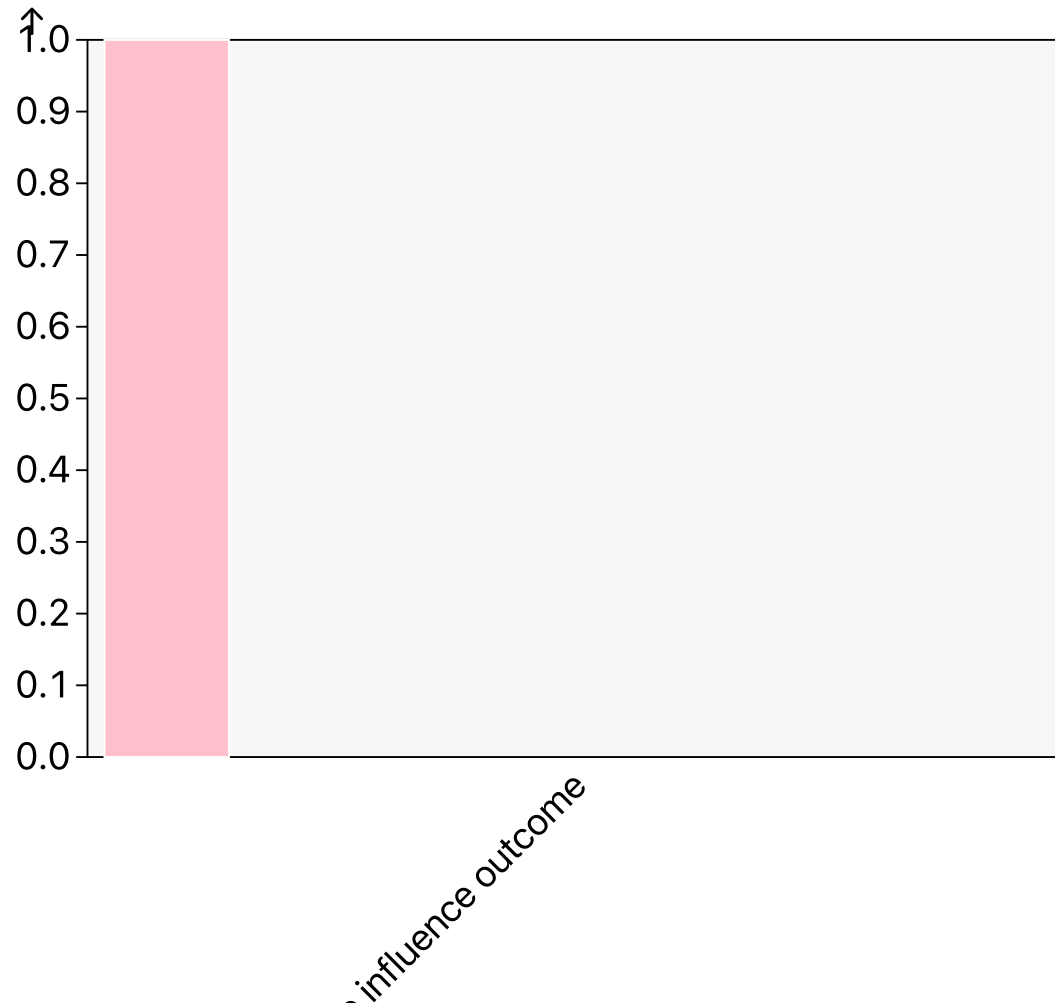
Antifa RAF IS alQaeda NPD/Heimat NSU PKK



Group responses - election violence

How is the group's violence connected to elections?

Antifa RAF IS alQaeda NPD/Heimat NSU PKK



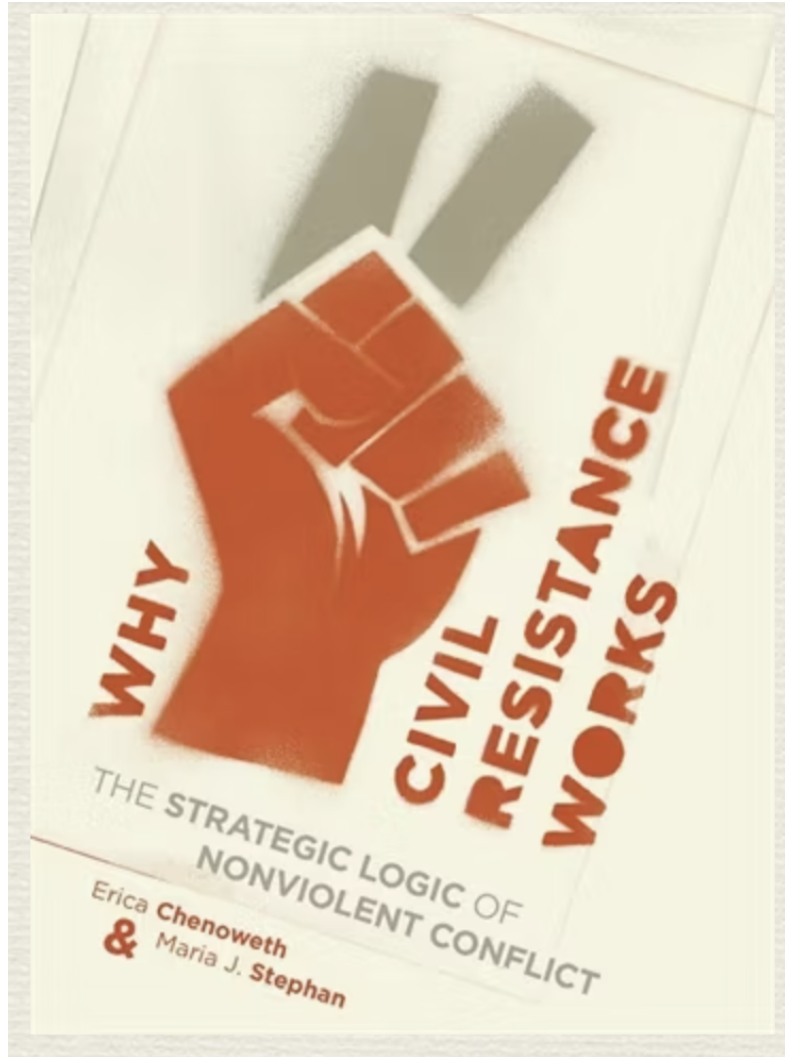
Group responses - election targeting

Back to Violence / Nonviolence

- background: Chenoweth and Stephan (2011)
- Kudelia (2018) and the case of Euromaidan in Ukraine
 - a puzzling case?
 - productive and counter-productive effects of violence
 - findings
- concluding question



Background: study of Chenoweth and Stephan (2011)



- research aim: determine relative success of nonviolent ('civil resistance' - Gene Sharp) or violent resistance
- cases of violent and non-violent campaigns between 1900 and 2006: 323 cases

Background: study of Chenoweth and Stephan (2011)



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Pay attention to the mechanisms that Prof. Chenoweth specifies in her brief explanation

Background: study of Chenoweth and Stephan (2011)

Pay attention to the mechanisms that Prof. Chenoweth specifies in her brief explanation

- nonviolent campaigns are better at eliciting broad and diverse support
- nonviolent campaigns create more defections among the opposition
- nonviolent campaigns have a broader set of tactics at their disposal
- nonviolent campaigns often maintain discipline even in the face of escalating oppression

Kudelia (2018) - refining Chenoweth and Stephan (2013)

- Ukraine's Euromaidan
 - what's going on in this case?
 - Yanukovych's regime: semi-authoritarian
- violent protests occurred...
 - **but** accounted for just 12 percent of all protests
 - **yet** concentrated in final month (Jan.-Feb. 2014) and in Kyiv

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“The success of violent protest tactics in Ukraine's case, **puzzling** from the standpoint of recent findings, has received no systematic, theoretically-driven scholarly treatment.”

(empirically, theoretically) puzzling or not...

- Kudelia (2018) - within-case qualitative process tracing of “actors’ choices using a rationalist theoretical”
 - rationalist = strategic choice rather than spontaneous reaction

(counter-)productive effects of violence - Kudelia (2019)

- violence **counter-productive**
 1. alienate current and potential supporters
 2. provoke a coercive response
 3. dampen international support for protests
- violence **productive**
 1. participatory character of protest violence
 2. embeddedness of violent groups and practices in a generally non-violent movement (*radical flanks*)
 3. capacity and willingness of violent activists to escalate beyond the **cost-tolerance threshold** of the regime
 - i.e., how much will regime tolerate? will it offer concessions?

Kudelia (2018) - findings

- violence complementing **already** and **continuing** high mobilisation is effective in making regime more sensitive to protest costs
- “a regime’s repressive escalation may decrease net participation costs by broadening support for militants among rank-and-file protesters and outside sympathizers”
- two-tiered orgs.: a violent vanguard and a non-violent base
 - strengthens the leverage of moderate opposition elites in bargaining with the regime
 - when used in conjunction with non-violent actions in response to intensifying repression, it **may deter** the regime **or even tip** the balance of power against it.
- your thoughts on these findings?

Relationship across a movement:

how do (or should) nonviolent
actors deal with violent
actors/groups within their
movement (**‘radical flanks’**)?
Infighting or solidarity?

Any questions, concerns, feedback this class?

Anonymous feedback here:

<https://forms.gle/NfF1pCfYMbkAT3WP6>

Alternatively, please send me an email: m.zeller@lmu.de

Questions about groups next meeting: (1) How does the group's use of violence evolve over time? (2) How are major acts of violence perpetrated? (3) Does the group show restraint in choosing targets? (4) Is the group's restraint more strategic or moral? (5) Does the group have internal mechanisms to prevent uncontrolled violence? (6) Does the group escalate violence in response to state actions?

References

- Chenoweth, Erica, and Maria J. Stephan. 2011. *Why Civil Resistance Works: The Strategic Logic of Nonviolent Conflict*. New York: Columbia University Press.
- Dahl, Marianne, Sirianne Dahlum, Hanne Fjelde, Haakon Gjerløw, Carl Henrik Knutsen, Carina Strøm-Sedgwick, and Tore Wig. 2025. "Mass Mobilization in the Modern Era: Introducing the Opposition Movements and Groups (OMG) Dataset, 1789–2019." *Comparative Political Studies*, August, 00104140251369330. <https://doi.org/10.1177/00104140251369330>.
- Harbers, Imke, Cécile Richetta, and Enrike van Wingerden. 2022. "Shaping Electoral Outcomes: Intra- and Anti-systemic Violence in Indian Assembly Elections." *British Journal of Political Science*, October, 1–17. <https://doi.org/10.1017/S0007123422000345>.
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- Zhukov, Yuri M, Christian Davenport, and Nadiya Kostyuk. 2019. "Introducing xSub: A New Portal for Cross-National Data on Subnational Violence." *Journal of Peace Research* 56 (4): 604–14. <https://doi.org/10.1177/0022343319836697>.